

Intervertebral Disc Disease (IVDD)

What is IVDD?

The spine is a stack of bones (vertebrae) with cushions (discs) between them. A healthy disc is like a jelly donut — a tough outer layer with a soft center. With age, the center hardens (like dried toothpaste) and the outer layer weakens. When the disc **herniates**, its material pushes into the spinal canal. This can happen with any activity, from a sneeze to a jump.

A herniated disc can injure the spinal cord by **compressing** it (like stepping on a garden hose), **bruising** it on impact, and causing **inflammation**.

Signs and stages

A disc in the **neck** can affect all four legs; a disc in the **mid/low back** affects the back legs.

Stage	What you see
1 — Pain only	Eating less, hiding, crying when picked up, avoiding stairs or jumping
2 — Wobbly	Walking but "drunk," scuffing or crossing legs
3 — Cannot walk	Moves legs but cannot walk without help; usually still controls bladder
4 — Paralyzed	Cannot move legs but can still feel the toes ; needs help to urinate
5 — No deep pain	Cannot move or feel the toes — most severe

Diagnosis

MRI gives the clearest picture of the spine and spinal cord and is needed to plan surgery. X-rays show bone only; CT is fast but does not show the health of the spinal cord.

Medical management (no surgery)

1. Strict rest for 4–6 weeks — the most important part:

- Crate or small pen; no running, jumping or stairs
- Carry your pet outside for short potty breaks only
- Continue until there is no pain or weakness, then return to activity gradually

2. Pain control for 1–2 weeks: anti-inflammatories, pain relievers (gabapentin, tramadol), muscle relaxants.

Works in more than half of pets, but **the problem often comes back**, and recurrences are usually worse. **Do not use chiropractic care.** Avoid jumping and rough play for life.

When is surgery recommended?

- Repeated episodes of pain or weakness
- Not improving with rest and medication
- Unable to walk
- Significant spinal cord compression on MRI

Surgery and recovery

The surgeon removes the disc material pressing on the spinal cord.

- Hospital stay of 1–3 days
- Sutures removed and plan updated at **2 weeks**
- Gradual return to normal activity after about **6 weeks**

Outcome

- If your pet can still **feel the toes**, surgery is about **90% successful**
- Only 10–25% have problems return after surgery — much lower than with rest alone
- If **deep pain is lost** (stage 5), success drops and about **10%** develop **myelomalacia** — a progressive, fatal softening of the spinal cord, usually within 3–14 days (about 30% in French Bulldogs)

Call us right away if your pet stops walking, loses feeling, cannot urinate, or pain worsens.